

PART 5: THE ENCOUNTER

When a party descends into a dungeon for the first time, they must be ready to deal with the strange creatures they will meet: some foul, some fair, some intelligent, some not; the variety is endless. Such a meeting is called an **encounter**.

The DM will find it useful to make a list of monster encounters before the adventure starts, noting their Number Appearing, Armor Class, hit points, and so forth. Having this information prepared before the adventure will speed play during the game. These monsters will often have a reason for being in the dungeon (such as looking for food or a special magic item, carrying a message, and so forth).

TIME IN ENCOUNTERS: "Normal" time in D&D games is measured in turns of 10 minutes each. Characters could actually do many things in one turn. In an encounter, the action is more detailed and is handled in "slow motion", so that the characters may have a chance to do many of the things that they want to. Time in encounters is measured in **rounds** of 10 seconds each. To help prevent DMs and players from becoming confused, the word **turn** should *always* be used for normal movement, while the word **round** should *only* be used for encounters and combat.

Since a round is ten seconds long and a turn is ten minutes long, there are 60 rounds to a turn. An encounter rarely takes as long as 60 rounds. When figuring out the amount of time spent in a dungeon, consider any encounter (including combat) of 60 rounds or less to have lasted one *full* turn. The additional time, if any, is spent resting sore muscles, recovering one's breath, cleaning weapons, and binding wounds.

ORDER OF PLAY: The DM must determine when and where a party of characters will have an encounter. First the monster must be chosen or randomly determined by the DM. Whether the encounter occurs or not should be a result of the actions the players take. The order of events given below should be followed to resolve an encounter.

Order of Events in One Game Turn

1. The DM rolls for wandering monsters (1d6; see page B53).
2. The party moves, enters room, listens, and searches.
3. If monsters are *not* encountered, the turn ends. If monsters are encountered, the DM rolls for the Number Appearing.
4. The DM rolls 2d6 to check the distance between the monsters and the party.
5. The DM rolls 1d6 for both the monsters and the party to check for surprise.

The DM and the party roll 1d6 or for initiative to see who moves first.
6. The DM rolls 2d6 for the Monster Reaction.
7. The party and the monsters react:
If both sides are willing to talk, the DM rolls for monster reactions and initiative, as necessary.
If one side runs away, the DM should check the chance of Evasion and Pursuit.
If combat begins, the DM should use the **Combat Sequence** to handle combat.
8. End of Turn. Where necessary, the DM should check the character's remaining hit points, whether or not they need rest (see page B24), any changes in the party's marching order,

or possessions, their encumbrance (see page B20), their sources of light, the durations of any spells in progress, and the total time the party has spent in the dungeon.

NUMBER APPEARING: Sometimes the number of monsters appearing is given by the design of the dungeon. Otherwise, a suggested range of the number of monsters appearing is listed with the monster description (as **No. Appearing**). The range given is for use on a dungeon level equal to the monster's level (hit dice), and should be changed if the monster is encountered on some other level of the dungeon. (Necessary changes are discussed under **MONSTERS**, page B30, and in the section on **Dungeon Mastering as a Fine Art**, page B60). The number appearing in parentheses after **No. Appearing** is the usual number of monsters appearing when encountered in the monster's underground lair or in the wilderness (the latter is for use with the D&D EXPERT SET).

DISTANCE: Situations often determine the distance between monsters and characters in an encounter. A monster seen "coming around a corner" 20 feet away, for example, is encountered at that distance. If it is uncertain how far away the monster is, roll 2d6 and multiply the result by 10. The resulting number (20-120) is the distance *in feet* at which the monster is first encountered.

SURPRISE: After finding the number of monsters appearing and their distance from the characters, the DM should then determine whether or not each side has been surprised. It is possible for *both* parties to be surprised! Sometimes there will be no surprise, due to the situation. **EXAMPLES:** A party is not likely to surprise a monster behind a closed door if the party has just fought a battle near that door. A party will not surprise that monster if the attempt to open the door fails (even once!). Surprise is only checked once per turn when a monster is first encountered.

If surprise is possible, the DM should roll 1d6 for each side in the encounter. A result of 1 or 2 for either side indicates that the side is surprised (unless given otherwise in the monster description).

If both sides are surprised, the surprise cancels out, and neither side moves nor fights that round.

If one side surprises the other, those not surprised may move and attack the first round, and the surprised enemy may not.

If neither side is surprised, it is necessary to determine which side takes the **initiative** for that round and acts first.

After the surprise round it is necessary to determine each round which side will react the fastest and thus move and attack first. This is called gaining the **initiative**.

INITIATIVE: To determine initiative, each side rolls 1d6 (the DM rolls for the monsters). The side with the higher roll may move first and attack first in combat for that round. If both sides roll the same number, the DM may either have both sides roll again, or may consider movement and combat for both sides to occur at the same time (known as **simultaneous** combat).

The side "with the initiative" has the first choice of actions. Members of that side may choose to fight, run, throw a spell, take defensive positions and wait to see what the other side does, start talking, or do anything else that the players or DM can imagine.

If combat occurs, the side with the initiative always strikes first in that round. Both sides should roll for initiative *each* round. If both sides tie on their initiative rolls, and combat is simultaneous, it is possible for both sides to be killed!

PAIR COMBAT (optional): The DM may choose to roll initiative for each character and the monsters he or she is fighting instead of for